

During the first manned mission to the Moon, the three astronauts on board Apollo 8 beamed back images of Earth as a planet in space.

THE MY LAI MASSACRE IN VIETNAM SENT SHOCK WAVES

through the US political establishment. My Lai lies in the South Vietnamese district of Son My, an area where the **Viet Cong** were deeply entrenched. On March 16, **US troops**, who had been on a "search and destroy" mission to root out communist fighters, **killed more than 500 Vietnamese civilians** in cold blood, many of them women and children. The massacre helped to **turn public opinion** against the Vietnam War, although the story was not made public until the following year.

By 1968, the Vietnam War was costing the US \$66 million a day. **Protests against the war escalated** as people questioned the US's role in the conflict. Vivid news reports showed horrific civilian casualties. On August 28, during the Democratic national convention in Chicago, **10,000 antiwar protesters gathered** and were confronted by 26,000 police and national guardsmen. The event was covered live on network TV.



War paraphernalia

A Chinese compass, a map case, and a map with enemy bases marked on, formed the basic kit for Vietcong militia during the Vietnam War.

On 4 April, the African-American civil rights leader **Martin Luther King, Jr.** (see panel, right) was assassinated in the southern US city of Memphis, Tennessee. King was shot on the balcony of his hotel as he was preparing to lead a march of sanitation workers **protesting against low wages**. The day before his assassination,

he delivered his famous speech, "I have seen the mountaintop ..." in Memphis, which seemed to predict his end, "... **I've seen the promised land**. I may not get there with you".

King's death sparked **widespread race riots** across the US that cost dozens of lives and led to damage worth millions of dollars. It hastened the process of "white

flight" from the inner cities that left many American downtowns virtually abandoned. **James Earl Ray**, a petty criminal, was convicted of King's murder and sentenced to 99 years in prison.

Senator Robert Kennedy (1925–68), increasingly opposed to the Vietnam War, struggled over his decision to challenge the Democratic party's incumbent president, **Lyndon Johnson**. His younger brother, Edward (Teddy), was against it; his wife, Ethel, urged him on. Many feared he would suffer the same fate as his brother John, who had been assassinated in 1963. He **announced his candidacy** on March 16, and two weeks later Johnson dropped out of the race. America was a wounded nation, reeling from the war and inner-city riots. Kennedy based his presidential election campaign on **inequality and social justice**.

On 5 June, **Robert Kennedy was shot** in a Los Angeles hotel after giving a victory speech to celebrate his win in the California Primary. A **Palestinian immigrant, Sirhan Sirhan**, fired at Kennedy as he was being escorted through the kitchen pantry of the Ambassador Hotel. Robert Kennedy's **support for Israel** was believed to have prompted the attack. He died the following day. His death, coming 63 days after that of Martin Luther King, Jr., made 1968 one of the most **volatile and traumatic** years in US history.

On November 6, Republican **Richard Nixon** (1913–94) emerged victorious in the **US presidential election**. He had based his campaign on rising crime and claimed he would restore law and order. It was a

dramatic comeback; Nixon was Dwight D. Eisenhower's vice-president and lost the presidential race to John F. Kennedy in 1960.

Enoch Powell (1912–98), a British right-wing politician, made a hugely **controversial speech** on April 20, in which he warned the government against opening the "floodgates" to **black immigrants**. He called for an immediate reduction in immigration, and viewed the future with foreboding. Quoting the Roman poet Virgil, he said, "... like the Roman, I seem to see the river Tiber foaming with much blood." His speech caused a **storm of protest**, and ended Powell's political ambitions.

Elsewhere in Europe, **France** experienced student **riots**, mass **protests**, and **strikes** throughout May, which brought the country

MARTIN LUTHER KING, JR. (1929–68)

A leading African-American civil rights campaigner in the US, Martin Luther King, Jr. rose to prominence in 1955, when he led a boycott of buses in Montgomery, Alabama, in protest against the state's transport segregation laws. In this, and his subsequent campaigns, he insisted on non-violence. King was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1964. Four years later, he was assassinated by a white gunman in Memphis, Tennessee.



200,000

THE NUMBER OF WARSAW PACT TROOPS THAT INVADED CZECHOSLOVAKIA

